

Day 119 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in TN History/Culture/Heritage (11): National Handicrafts Award for TN's Stone Carving Tradition

READING MATERIAL

Covers the National Handicrafts Awards ceremony (December 2025) and Tamil Nadu's recognition in the stone carving category.

Q: When was the National Handicrafts Awards ceremony held, and which years' awards did it cover?

A: 9 December 2025, in New Delhi — conferring National Handicrafts Awards for BOTH 2023 and 2024 (a combined ceremony covering 2 years).

Q: Who presented the awards, and who from Tamil Nadu was honoured, in which category?

A: President Droupadi Murmu presented the awards. T. Baskaran of Tamil Nadu received the National Award for 2024 in the STONE CARVING category.

Q: Why is a stone carving award particularly significant for Tamil Nadu?

A: Tamil Nadu has a long, renowned stone-sculpture tradition, most famously associated with the Pallava-era monuments at Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram) — this award recognises a living artisan continuing that ancient craft tradition.

Q: Name 2 other artisans (from other states) honoured at the same ceremony.

A: Rupban Chitrakar (West Bengal, painting category) and Baldev Baghmare (Madhya Pradesh, tribal artisans category).

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. The National Handicrafts Awards (for 2023 and 2024) ceremony was held on:

- A. 9 October 2025
- B. 9 November 2025
- C. 9 December 2025 ✓**
- D. 9 January 2026

Explanation: 9 December 2025. [hard, web-research]

2. T. Baskaran of Tamil Nadu received the National Handicrafts Award 2024 in which category?

- A. Painting
- B. Stone carving ✓**
- C. Handloom weaving
- D. Pottery

Explanation: Stone carving. [medium, web-research]

3. Who presented the National Handicrafts Awards at this ceremony?

- A. The Prime Minister
- B. The Union Culture Minister
- C. President Droupadi Murmu ✓**
- D. The Vice President

Explanation: President Droupadi Murmu. [easy, web-research]

4. Tamil Nadu's stone carving tradition (honoured by this award) is most famously associated with which historical monuments?

- A. Brihadeeswarar Temple, Thanjavur
- B. Pallava-era monuments at Mahabalipuram ✓**
- C. Meenakshi Temple, Madurai
- D. Ramanathaswamy Temple, Rameswaram

Explanation: Pallava-era monuments at Mahabalipuram. [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Compound Interest

READING MATERIAL

Compound Interest is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills. Real exam evidence shows TNPSC tests the standard CI formula, a useful SI-vs-CI shortcut, AND disguises CI as 'successive percentage change' word problems (depreciation, year-over-year growth) — recognize all three shapes.

Q: Formula: What is the Compound Interest formula, and the shortcut for the DIFFERENCE between SI and CI over 2 years?

A: Amount = $P(1+R/100)^T$, so CI = Amount – P. For exactly 2 years, there's a shortcut: $CI - SI = P \times (R/100)^2$. This avoids computing CI and SI separately when you only need their difference.

Q: Real exam (2022): Find the difference between SI and CI for 2 years on a principal of Rs.5,000 at 8% per annum.

A: Using the shortcut: difference = $P \times (R/100)^2 = 5000 \times (0.08)^2 = 5000 \times 0.0064 = \text{Rs.}32$. (Full check: SI = $5000 \times 8 \times 2/100 = 800$. CI = $5000 \times (1.08^2 - 1) = 5000 \times 0.1664 = 832$. Difference = $832 - 800 = 32$ ✓.)

Q: Real exam (2022): Find the compound interest on Rs.5,000 at 12% per annum for 2 years, compounded annually.

A: CI = $P \times ((1+R/100)^T - 1) = 5000 \times (1.12^2 - 1) = 5000 \times (1.2544 - 1) = 5000 \times 0.2544 = \text{Rs.}1,272$.

Q: Real exam (2025): A sum becomes Rs.13,380 after 3 years and Rs.20,070 after 6 years on compound interest. Find the original sum.

A: The amount after 6 years equals the amount after 3 years multiplied by the SAME growth factor again (since compounding is multiplicative): $(1+R/100)^3 = 20070/13380 = 1.5$. The sum itself: $P = \text{Amount-after-3-years} \div (1+R/100)^3 = 13380 \div 1.5 = \text{Rs.}8,920$.

Q: Real exam (2024): A motorcycle's value 2 years ago was Rs.80,000. It depreciates 4% in the first year, then increases 4% in the second year. Find the present value.

A: Apply each year's change as its own multiplier, in sequence — this is compound interest with a changing/mixed rate: $80,000 \times 0.96$ (first year, -4%) $\times 1.04$ (second year, +4%) = $80,000 \times 0.9984 = \text{Rs.}79,872$. Note the result is slightly LESS than the original Rs.80,000 — a decrease followed by an equal-percentage increase never fully cancels out, since the increase applies to a smaller base.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Find the difference between SI and CI for 2 years on a principal of Rs.8,000 at 5% per annum.

- A. Rs.18
- B. Rs.20 ✓**
- C. Rs.22
- D. Rs.25

Explanation: Difference = $P \times (R/100)^2 = 8000 \times (0.05)^2 = 8000 \times 0.0025 = \text{Rs.}20$. [medium, authored]

2. Find the compound interest on Rs.10,000 at 10% per annum for 2 years, compounded annually.

- A. Rs.2,000
- B. Rs.2,100 ✓**
- C. Rs.2,200
- D. Rs.1,900

Explanation: CI = $10000 \times (1.10^2 - 1) = 10000 \times 0.21 = \text{Rs.}2,100$. [easy, authored]

3. A sum becomes Rs.16,000 after 2 years and Rs.19,360 after 4 years on compound interest. Find the original sum.

- A. Rs.12,500
- B. Rs.13,000
- C. Rs.13,223 ✓**
- D. Rs.14,000

Explanation: $(1+R/100)^2 = 19360/16000 = 1.21$. $P = 16000/1.21 \approx \text{Rs.}13,223$. [hard, authored]

4. A machine valued at Rs.50,000 depreciates by 10% in the first year and a further 10% in the second year. Find its value after 2 years.

- A. Rs.40,000
- B. Rs.40,500 ✓**
- C. Rs.41,000
- D. Rs.39,500

Explanation: $50,000 \times 0.90 \times 0.90 = 50,000 \times 0.81 = \text{Rs.}40,500$. [medium, authored]

5. Find the compound interest on Rs.20,000 at 15% per annum for 2 years, compounded annually.

A. Rs.6,000

B. Rs.6,450 ✓

C. Rs.6,200

D. Rs.6,500

Explanation: $CI = 20000 \times (1.15^2 - 1) = 20000 \times 0.3225 = \text{Rs.}6,450$. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Prose: "Learning the Game" (Book Extract) — Sachin Tendulkar

READING MATERIAL

A first-person extract from Sachin Tendulkar's memoir, recounting how his brother Ajit introduced him (at age 11) to coach Ramakant Achrekar at Shardashram Vidyamandir, and the rigorous daily training that followed — including hardships like having only one set of cricket clothes and the now-famous 'one-rupee coin on the stumps' concentration drill.

Q: Who are 'the narrator' and the author of "Learning the Game", and which two cricketers did he admire and try to emulate?

A: The narrator IS the author — Sachin Tendulkar himself, in this first-person memoir extract. He admired and tried to emulate Sunil Gavaskar and Viv Richards.

Q: Which school did young Sachin initially attend, and who suggested he change schools, and to where?

A: He initially attended New English School. Coach Ramakant Achrekar suggested changing his school — to Shardashram Vidyamandir, where Achrekar himself coached cricket.

Q: Real exam: How old was Sachin when he first went to Achrekar's cricket camp, and who introduced him there?

A: 11 years old (confirmed by a real exam question, which also notes Achrekar himself started playing cricket at the same age). His elder brother Ajit introduced him to Achrekar.

Q: What was Achrekar's initial reaction to young Sachin's performance, and how did Ajit get him a second chance?

A: Achrekar initially suggested Ajit bring the boy back when he was OLDER (i.e., rejecting him at first). Ajit insisted Sachin deserved another chance because he knew Sachin could perform better — Achrekar agreed to watch again secretly (pretending to leave, observing from behind a tree/at a distance), and this time Sachin played confidently and was accepted into the camp.

Q: What was the daily training routine like during the summer camp, and what hardships did young Sachin endure?

A: TWO sessions a day — one in the morning and one in the evening, at Shivaji Park — with school squeezed in between. With only ONE set of cricket clothes, he had to wash and dry them between sessions; his pockets were often wet from the effort/perspiration of the rigorous training.

Q: What did Ajit discuss with Sachin during their bus journeys to and from practice, and what was Achrekar's famous concentration drill?

A: Ajit discussed the NUANCES OF BATTING with Sachin during their bus journeys. Achrekar's well-known drill: placing a one-rupee coin on top of the stumps during the last 15 minutes of net practice — whoever bowled Sachin out kept the coin, but if Sachin batted through unbowled, HE kept the coin — a method designed to build intense concentration and mental discipline.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. In "Learning the Game", the narrator is:

- A. A fictional cricketer
- B. Sachin Tendulkar himself (first-person memoir) ✓**
- C. Ramakant Achrekar
- D. Ajit Tendulkar

Explanation: Sachin Tendulkar himself. [easy, web-research]

2. Which two cricketers did the narrator admire and try to emulate?

- A. Kapil Dev and Sunil Gavaskar
- B. Sunil Gavaskar and Viv Richards ✓**
- C. Sachin Tendulkar and Kapil Dev
- D. Viv Richards and Kapil Dev

Explanation: Sunil Gavaskar and Viv Richards. [medium, web-research]

3. Who was the cricket coach at Shardashram Vidyamandir?

- A. Ramakant Achrekar ✓**
- B. Ajit Tendulkar
- C. Sunil Gavaskar
- D. Viv Richards

Explanation: Ramakant Achrekar. [easy, web-research]

4. How old was Sachin when he first went to Achrekar's cricket camp?

- A. 9 years old
- B. 10 years old
- C. 11 years old ✓**
- D. 12 years old

Explanation: 11 years old. [medium, question-bank-2022]

5. What did Achrekar initially suggest to Ajit regarding the narrator?

- A. To change his batting style
- B. To bring him back when he was older ✓**
- C. To focus on studies instead
- D. To join another coaching camp

Explanation: To bring him back when he was older. [medium, web-research]

6. What was the narrator's daily practice routine during the summer camp?

- A. One session in the morning only
- B. One session in the evening only
- C. Two sessions — morning and evening ✓**
- D. Two sessions — afternoon and evening

Explanation: Two sessions, morning and evening. [medium, web-research]

7. What did Ajit discuss with the narrator during their bus journeys?

- A. Schoolwork
- B. Bowling techniques
- C. The nuances of batting ✓**
- D. Fielding strategies

Explanation: The nuances of batting. [medium, web-research]

8. How did the narrator manage with only one set of cricket clothes during the camp?

- A. He borrowed clothes from friends
- B. He washed and dried them between sessions ✓**
- C. He bought extra clothes
- D. He wore them dirty every day

Explanation: He washed and dried them between sessions. [medium, web-research]

9. What was Achrekar's famous training drill to build the narrator's concentration?

- A. Placing a one-rupee coin on the stumps during the last 15 minutes of practice ✓**
- B. Making him bat blindfolded
- C. Having him practise alone at night
- D. Rewarding him with sweets for every run scored

Explanation: Placing a one-rupee coin on the stumps. [hard, web-research]

10. What did Achrekar suggest for the narrator to improve his cricket, regarding his education?

- A. Changing his school ✓**
- B. Playing more matches
- C. Focusing only on studies
- D. Attending more camps abroad

Explanation: Changing his school (to Shardashram Vidyamandir). [medium, web-research]